Mahavira's Path

Ten stations, from a noisy market in 600 BCE to a quiet place called Siddhashila. Keep your textbook open. Every answer is hiding in it somewhere.

Name: Date: Stars ★:

1 The Grumbling Market

Why people wanted something new (Social conditions)

Vaishali, around 600 BCE. You've slipped back in time and landed in a busy market. Listen to what people are grumbling about.

Dhana, a merchant: "My carts carry spices and cloth all over the land. I'm richer than many nobles! But since I was born a Vaishya, people still don't give me respect."

Govinda, a farmer: "The priests took my strong bullock for a sacrifice. How will I plough my field now?"

Little Sumati: "At the yajna, the priest chants in Sanskrit. I don't understand a single word."

An old teacher: "The Upanishads say rituals don't matter much. Knowledge and right conduct matter."

Everybody was looking for a fairer, simpler path. Two new paths were about to appear.

Pick words from the box and write them in the blanks. Cross each word off as you use it. Two words are tricksters and don't fit anywhere!

birth · Brahmins · common languages · equality · farming · Greek · Jainism · mantras · occupation · sacrifices · Sanskrit · trade · Upanishads · Vaishyas · weapons

1. Long ago, your varna (social class) depended on your _____. By the 6th century BCE it was decided by _____, which made society unfair.
2. Farming and _____ made merchants, the _____, wealthy. But they didn't get respect, so they supported new religions that promised _____.
3. Only the _____ could chant the hymns and _____, which were in _____, a language most people could not understand.
4. Animal _____ hurt farmers, because animals were needed for _____.
5. Texts called the _____ questioned rituals and encouraged knowledge and right conduct.
6. _____ and Buddhism rejected sacrifices, promoted kindness, and were taught in _____.

2 Who Am I?

Riddles from Mahavira's life

A baby named **Vardhamana** was born into a noble Kshatriya family. He grew up a prince, married Princess Yashoda, and had a daughter called Priyadarshana. Then one day he walked away from the palace forever. Why? He wanted to free his soul from the cycle of birth and rebirth.

Each riddle below is spoken by a *place, number or thing* from his story. Can you guess who's talking?

Circle the right answer.

1. I'm a town near Vaishali in today's Bihar. Around 599 BCE, a baby prince was born in me.

a Pavapuri **b** Kundagrama **c** Rajgir **d** Kalinga

2. I'm the king of Magadha. I was Mahavira's relative AND later his follower.

a Bimbisara **b** Chandragupta **c** Kharavela **d** Chetaka

3. I'm the age when the prince left home to become an ascetic.

a 18 **b** 30 **c** 42 **d** 72

4. Under my branches, near a river, he found perfect knowledge.

a Banyan tree **b** Peepal tree **c** Sala tree **d** Mango tree

5. My name means 'perfect knowledge'.

a Nirvana **b** Kevala Jnana **c** Moksha **d** Tapasya

6. I'm a title that means 'conqueror of the self'. His followers are named after me.

a Raja **b** Jina **c** Guru **d** Rishi

7. I'm the easy, everyday language he taught in, instead of Sanskrit.

a Tamil **b** Greek **c** Prakrit **d** Persian

8. Near Rajgir in Bihar, he attained nirvana in me at age 72.

a Pavapuri **b** Kundagrama **c** Valabhi **d** Vaishali

9. Jains believe his free soul now lives in me, a place of perfect peace.

a Siddhashila **b** Swarga **c** Valabhi **d** Agiary

10. I'm the number of great teachers (tirthankaras) in Jainism. Mahavira was the last.

a 12 **b** 24 **c** 5 **d** 3

3 Number Magic

Mahavira's life in numbers

Numbers can tell a story too. Fill in each box. You'll need the textbook, plus a little bit of maths.

Tricky bit: BCE years count *backwards*, like a rocket countdown. So someone born in 599 BCE is older in 527 BCE, not younger!

Age when he left the palace ☐

Years he wandered, fasting and meditating ☐

So his age when he got Kevala Jnana = 30 + 12 = ☐

Age when he attained nirvana ☐

So he taught people for 72 − 42 = ___ years ☐

Born ~599 BCE, nirvana 527 BCE. Check: 599 − 527 = ☐

Now put his life in order. Write 1 for what happened first, up to 8 for what happened last.

☐ Marries Princess Yashoda; daughter Priyadarshana is born

☐ Attains Kevala Jnana under a Sala tree, becomes a Jina

☐ Attains nirvana at Pavapuri at 72

☐ Councils collect his teachings into the Jain Agamas

☐ Wanders for 12 years, fasting and meditating

☐ Travels and teaches in Prakrit; starts an order of monks and nuns

☐ Leaves home at 30 to become an ascetic

☐ Born in Kundagrama, near Vaishali

Draw it Draw the Sala tree by the river where Mahavira found Kevala Jnana.

4 Vow Detective

The Five Great Vows (Mahavratas)

Jain monks and nuns take five big promises called the **Mahavratas**. The first four were older. Mahavira added the fifth one.

Your job, detective: read each case and decide which vow the person is following.

Write the matching code in the box.

AH = Ahimsa **SA** = Satya **AS** = Asteya **AP** = Aparigraha **BR** = Brahmacharya

☐ **1.** A line of ants is marching across the kitchen counter. Shreshta gently moves them outside on a piece of paper instead of spraying them.

☐ **2.** Arjun broke a glass. When Mum asks, he says calmly and kindly, “It was me, sorry.”

☐ **3.** Someone left a shiny new gel pen on the bench. Meera hands it to the class teacher.

☐ **4.** Kabir already has three cricket bats. He decides he doesn't need a fourth and gives one to his cousin.

☐ **5.** A Jain monk chooses not to marry so he can put all his energy into spiritual goals.

☐ **6.** A Jain nun walks slowly and looks at the ground so she doesn't step on an insect.

Circle the right answer.

1. Quick one: which vow did Mahavira add to the original four?

a Ahimsa **b** Satya **c** Brahmacharya **d** Asteya

Draw it Draw yourself keeping one of the five vows today. Which vow is it?

5 The Three Jewels

Triratna: the way to moksha

Think about making a perfect dosa. First you have to **trust** the recipe. Then you have to **know** how much batter to pour and when to flip it. Finally you have to actually **do** it, carefully. Miss any one and there's no dosa!

Jains say reaching **moksha** (freedom from the cycle of birth and death) works the same way. You need three jewels together.

Believe	Know	Do
Trust the recipe	Understand the steps	Cook carefully

Write the matching code in the box.

F = Right faith **K** = Right knowledge **C** = Right conduct

- ☐ **1.** I'm Samyak Darshana. I mean having true belief in the teachings of Jainism.
- ☐ **2.** I'm Samyak Jnana. I help you understand reality and the difference between soul and non-soul.
- ☐ **3.** I'm Samyak Charitra. I'm living a moral, disciplined life by following the Five Great Vows.
- ☐ **4.** In the dosa story, I'm the part where you actually cook.

6 The Elephant in the Dark

Main principles of Jainism

Six friends are blindfolded and led to an elephant. Each touches one part.

Trunk "It's a snake!"	**Leg** "No, a tree trunk!"	**Ear** "It's a big fan."
Tail "It's a rope!"	**Side** "It's a wall."	**Tusk** "It's a spear."

They argue all day. Who is right? *All of them, a little bit.* Each knows one side of the truth. This Jain idea is called **Anekantavada**: truth has many sides, so respect other viewpoints.

Now match each clue to the Jain principle it describes.

Write the matching code in the box.

AH = Ahimsa **AN** = Anekantavada **AP** = Aparigraha **KR** = Karma & Rebirth **NG** = No Creator God **MO** = Moksha

- ☐ **1.** The elephant story is all about me.
- ☐ **2.** I'm like a boomerang. Every action comes back with consequences.
- ☐ **3.** I say non-violence is the highest duty.
- ☐ **4.** I say the universe has always existed, and each soul is responsible for its own destiny.
- ☐ **5.** Let go of greed and clinging to things to purify the soul.
- ☐ **6.** When the soul is free of all karma, it is never reborn and reaches eternal peace.

7 Case File: How It Spread

Worship, practices and why Jainism grew

Jainism started small, with one teacher walking from village to village. Soon it spread across India. Detective, your case file has nine clues, and three of them are **fake**. Tick only the true reasons and facts.

Tick ✓ the true clues. Cross × the three fakes.

- ☐ **1.** Kings like Chandragupta Maurya and Kharavela of Kalinga supported it (patronage).
- ☐ **2.** Mahavira preached in Prakrit, so people understood him easily.
- ☐ **3.** Jains performed big fire sacrifices and animal offerings.
- ☐ **4.** Jain armies conquered new lands and forced people to join.
- ☐ **5.** Jains worship the 24 tirthankaras, who showed the path to liberation.
- ☐ **6.** Farmers and traders welcomed the message of ahimsa.
- ☐ **7.** Mahavira organised followers into groups called Sanghas, which carried the teachings far.
- ☐ **8.** Mahavira taught only in Sanskrit, so just priests could understand.
- ☐ **9.** People were unhappy with social inequality and complicated Vedic rituals.

Draw it Draw a Jain monk or nun walking from village to village to share the teachings.

8 White Robes or Sky?

Shvetambara and Digambara

Over time, Jains split into two groups. Both follow Mahavira, but they disagree on how strictly to give up worldly things.

Memory trick: *Shveta* means white. Think “Sh-veta, white sh-eet”: Shvetambaras wear white. *Digambara* means “sky-clad”: the sky is their only clothing.

Write the matching code in the box.

S = Shvetambara **D** = Digambara **B** = Both

- ☐ **1.** Name means ‘white-clad’.
- ☐ **2.** Name means ‘sky-clad’.
- ☐ **3.** Monks believe they should not wear any clothes at all. It shows total detachment.
- ☐ **4.** Monks and nuns wear simple white clothes. They say clothes don't go against renunciation.
- ☐ **5.** Their sacred texts were written down at the Council of Valabhi (5th century CE).
- ☐ **6.** Most live in Gujarat, Rajasthan and parts of Maharashtra.
- ☐ **7.** Mainly found in Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and parts of Rajasthan.
- ☐ **8.** Follow the teachings of Mahavira.

Design it Design a badge for Jainism: one half white robes, the other half the open sky.

9 Secret Scrolls

Jainism's gifts to Indian culture

An old Jain library has six scrolls. Their titles got scrambled by a naughty monkey. Read the clue, unscramble the word and type it in.

One letter goes in each box.

R R A K T I P

Most Jain literature was written in this language.

_ _ _ _ _ _ _

M A R A H D A A H D I G

The mixed dialect Mahavira preached in, so common people understood.

_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _

A A N A N K D

Jainism helped this South Indian language's early literature grow.

_ _ _ _ _ _ _

I S A A H M

This principle discouraged animal sacrifice.

_ _ _ _ _ _

C O O S L H S

Jains set these up so children could learn.

_ _ _ _ _ _ _

P T S L A O S I H

Jains set these up so the sick could get care.

_ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _

Circle the right answer.

1. Jains also built rest houses. Who were these for?

a Kings only b Travellers c Soldiers d Priests

2. In some Jain temples, ancient stone wheels have spun for hundreds of years, turned gently by hand during prayer. What are they called?

a Dharmachakras b Agiary c Sanghas d Agamas

10 Word Hunt

Glossary words, plus a visitor from far away

These are the chapter's special words. Use the word box. One word in it is a trickster.

Pick words from the box and write them in the blanks. Cross each word off as you use it. One word is a trickster.

Agamas | ascetic | Karma | Mantra | Moksha | Nirvana | Patronage | Tirthankara | Yajna

1. A _____ is a spiritual teacher who has attained enlightenment and shows the way to moksha.
2. A _____ is a sacred word or phrase repeated during prayers or meditation.
3. _____ is the effect of a person's actions that decides their future.
4. _____ means freedom from the cycle of birth and death.
5. _____ is the state of complete liberation. Mahavira reached it at Pavapuri.
6. _____ is support from a king or a wealthy person to promote religion, art or learning.
7. An _____ gives up worldly comforts for a spiritual life, as Mahavira did at 30.
8. Mahavira's teachings were written down in a group of texts called the Jain _____.

Circle the right answer.

1. Around the World riddle: My prophet was born near the Aral Sea. I believe in one god, Ahuramazda. My fire temples are called agiary, and my holy book is the Avesta. The Parsis of India follow me. Who am I?

a Buddhism **b** Zoroastrianism **c** Jainism **d** Hinduism

2. Zoroastrians value good thoughts, good words and good deeds. Jains say you can create bad karma through actions, words or…?

a dreams **b** thoughts **c** money **d** food

11 Thinker's Corner

No wrong answers here, just your own thinking

These questions come from the boxes in your textbook. Write a few lines for each.

1. Let's Begin: What if you could never harm any living creature, not even by mistake? Would it change the way you speak, eat or move around?

Nudge: Think about: mosquitoes, what's on your plate, walking on grass, unkind words.

2. Find Out: What important values can we learn from Mahavira? Give examples.

Nudge: Pick 2–3 vows and give a school or home example for each, like the detective cases.

3. Think and Answer: There is violence and hatred in the world today. How are Mahavira's teachings still useful?

Nudge: Ahimsa → less fighting. Anekantavada → respecting people who disagree. Aparigraha → less greed.

4. SDG Connect: Which Jain values support SDG 16 (Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions)?

Nudge: Non-violence, truthfulness, equality, self-discipline. How would a class or a country change if everyone practised them?

5. GeoTask: Name two regions where Jainism became popular and say why they mattered.

Nudge: Bihar (Magadha): Mahavira was born, taught and attained nirvana there. Karnataka: Digambara Jains, early Kannada literature. Gujarat/Rajasthan: traders who supported Jainism.